



When people hear the word *spirituality*, many immediately think of organised religion. Others reject the term altogether, associating it with dogma, ritual, or personal belief. Yet spirituality, in its broadest sense, speaks to something far more fundamental: the way human beings understand reality, derive meaning, and orient themselves in the world.

Whether one is religious, agnostic, or secular, every person lives according to a set of deeply held assumptions about what is true, what is valuable, what is worth pursuing, and how one ought to act. These assumptions form what we call a **worldview**.

The Worldview LOA Framework did not emerge in isolation. Its intellectual roots extend into sociology, philosophy, anthropology and Strong Structuration Theory, but its deeper inspiration came from a much older tradition of thinking about human nature—one that recognises that beneath our behaviours lie enduring questions about morality, relationships, and power.

The Three Colors of Worldview model provided the original spark.

The model proposes that every culture, and indeed every individual, carries a unique mixture of three primary worldview orientations: **Guilt–Innocence**, **Honor–Shame**, and **Fear–Power**. These



are not rigid categories or competing worldviews. Rather, they are the fundamental "building blocks" from which every worldview is constructed. Like the three primary colours of light, they combine in different proportions to create the remarkable diversity of human cultures.

This insight profoundly influenced my own thinking.

Over many years of consulting and leadership development across Africa, Europe, the Middle East and Asia, I repeatedly observed that executives facing identical organisational challenges interpreted them in remarkably different ways. Some instinctively focused on rules and fairness. Others prioritised relationships and collective honour. Still others were primarily concerned with certainty, authority and reducing risk.

These differences could not be adequately explained by personality, leadership style, or organisational culture alone.

Something deeper was at work.

The Three Colors model offered a compelling explanation. It suggested that beneath every decision lies a deeper moral and spiritual orientation—a way of interpreting reality that has often been shaped over generations through culture, tradition and, for many people, religious belief.

This does not imply that one must subscribe to any particular faith tradition. Every major religion, as well as many secular philosophies, grapples with remarkably similar human concerns.

What is right?

To whom do I owe responsibility?

How should I exercise power?

How do I find meaning?

How do I respond to suffering?

These are spiritual questions because they concern the deepest convictions through which people make sense of life. They transcend denominational boundaries and continue to shape human behaviour, whether acknowledged or not.

The Worldview LOA Framework builds on this foundation.

Rather than describing cultural differences alone, LOA explains how worldviews become translated into action through three deep evaluative structures: **Legitimacy, Obligation, and Agency**.

Legitimacy concerns what an individual considers to be right, appropriate, or morally acceptable.

Obligation reflects the duties and responsibilities that a person believes they owe to others, whether those others are family, colleagues, organisations, communities, or a higher purpose.

Agency captures an individual's perception of their capacity to act, influence events, and shape outcomes.

Together, these three dimensions explain why people exposed to identical organisational circumstances often make profoundly different decisions.

The connection with the Three Colors model becomes apparent.

The Guilt–Innocence orientation strongly influences perceptions of legitimacy. People naturally evaluate situations by asking whether actions are right or wrong, lawful or unlawful, ethical or unethical. Rules, principles and justice become dominant reference points.

Honor–Shame primarily shapes obligation. Here, identity is inseparable from relationships. Duty extends beyond personal preference to include family, community, profession and organisation. Maintaining trust, reputation and belonging becomes central to responsible action.

Fear–Power influences agency. It shapes how individuals perceive uncertainty, authority and control. Some seek security through hierarchy and established authority. Others develop confidence through trusted relationships or personal capability. Either way, perceptions of power profoundly influence the willingness to act.

Importantly, none of these orientations is inherently superior to another.

Each reflects an adaptive human response to life's enduring challenges.

A strong Guilt–Innocence orientation promotes justice and accountability.

Honor–Shame strengthens loyalty, community and social cohesion.

Fear–Power cultivates vigilance, resilience and an appreciation for leadership during uncertainty.

Problems emerge only when one orientation becomes dominant to the exclusion of the others.

An excessive emphasis on guilt can create organisations paralysed by compliance and blame.

An overemphasis on honour may discourage constructive disagreement in favour of preserving appearances.



A culture dominated by fear can centralise authority, suppress innovation and inhibit learning.

Healthy organisations require all three dimensions to exist in dynamic balance.

This insight has profound implications for organisational transformation.

Many change initiatives fail because leaders assume that resistance is primarily cognitive or behavioural. They introduce new structures, redesign processes, launch communication campaigns and invest heavily in technology.

Yet employees are not simply responding to new systems.

They are interpreting those systems through deeply embedded worldviews.

A restructuring may be experienced as a rational efficiency programme by one executive, as a violation of loyalty by another, and as a threat to personal security by a third.

The organisational event is identical.

The interpretation is radically different.

The Worldview LOA Framework explains why.

Worldviews shape how people evaluate legitimacy, define obligation and perceive agency. These three evaluative structures, in turn, influence the choices leaders ultimately make.

Transformation therefore begins long before implementation.

It begins with interpretation.

This is where spirituality becomes practically relevant to leadership.

Regardless of one's religious convictions, leadership inevitably requires engagement with questions of meaning, purpose, identity, responsibility and hope. Organisations are communities of human beings, not merely systems of production. Their members bring with them deeply held beliefs about justice, honour, trust and authority that influence every strategic conversation and every significant decision.

Ignoring these deeper dimensions does not make them disappear.

It simply leaves them unexplored.



For me, the Three Colors of Worldview remains one of the most elegant ways of understanding the spiritual architecture of human behaviour. It reminds us that beneath cultural diversity lie common human concerns, and that these concerns continue to shape how leaders interpret reality.

The Worldview LOA Framework extends this insight by providing a mechanism through which those deep worldviews become visible in executive judgement and organisational action.

In an increasingly fragmented world, effective leadership will require more than analytical capability or technical expertise.

It will require the wisdom to understand how people construct meaning, how they define what is legitimate, what they believe they owe to others, and how they perceive their capacity to act.

Ultimately, organisational transformation is not simply about changing systems.

It is about engaging the deepest convictions through which people understand the world—and helping them discover new possibilities for action within it.

That is, fundamentally, a spiritual endeavour.